

Should steps (strategies, projects, activities) be siloed under individual outcomes?

Some strategy and outcomes modeling, tables or frameworks implicitly, or explicitly, encourage siloing of steps (strategies, projects, activities) under individual outcomes. However, within DoView Planning, any step in a strategy/outcomes diagram or outcomes framework needs to be able to be represented as potentially influencing any outcome(s) if this is what is believed to be the case. In other words, strategy/outcomes diagrams and outcomes frameworks should always allow many-to-many relationships between steps and outcomes.

One popular approach to outcomes work is to put an initiative's outcomes into a table format. However, this can inadvertently lead to siloing. Usually, you put an outcome into a row in a column on the left-hand side of a table and then list strategies, projects or activities in the same row in a column just to the right of the particular outcome. If there is an implicit or explicit rule of not allowing a step (strategy, project or activity) to appear more than once in the strategy column on the left you can inadvertently end up enforcing an implicit siloing rule within the outcomes framework. Another problem is that siloing can end up distorting the wording used for outcomes statements. The names for outcomes can inadvertently end up being changed into headings that summarize a group of strategies with similar mechanisms of operation rather than being actual 'outcomes' in the outside world.

You can also inadvertently cause siloing when requiring that initiatives estimate the cost of attempting to influence each of a number of individual outcomes. You do this by summing up the costs of the strategies influencing each outcome. However, if this requirement is interpreted to mean that the cost of any strategy can only be allocated to a single outcome, this enforces siloing. Dividing the cost of a strategy across more than one outcome can avoid this. However you then need to consider if judgments about this division are credible or not in a particular instance.

Siloing can completely derail some approaches to strategy work. For instance, one strategic planning approach is based on identifying 'key drivers' - steps contributing to more than one higher-level outcome. However, if there is siloing, you can, by definition, never identify any key drivers. Lastly, when using outcomes and strategy apps and platforms, it is important to use software that allows many-to-many relationships between boxes so that you can avoid inadvertent siloing.